

MISHAROTAM: What's really going on?

By Joseph Mosseri

Pesah is nearly upon us. We are all busy shopping, cleaning, cooking for the holiday which celebrates and commemorates many themes, including freedom from tyranny and the birth of our nation. On the first two nights of Pesah we read the Haggadah and we symbolically reenact the exodus with the recitation of “MISHAROTAM”.

What's “Misharotam” you ask? It occurs right after the fourth step in the Haggadah entitled Yahass. The head of the household splits the middle massah into two pieces, a smaller one that is replaced between the two whole massot and a larger piece that is wrapped in a towel and saved to eat for the afiqomin. At that point, before continuing with Ha Lahma ‘Anyah, each person at the table holds this wrapped massah in their right hand over their left shoulder and says “Misharotam Seroorot BeSimlotam ‘Al Shikhmam Oobné Yisrael ‘Asoo Kidbar Moshéh”, after which there are a couple of questions and answers. In some communities not all present do this, rather only the head of the household does this, in other communities each person walks around the table while saying it.

As beautiful as this custom is, I have always been troubled and confused by a glaring problem that most seem to have glossed over. The Misharotam statement we recite is the combination of the latter half of one pasooq and the following half of the next pasooq. Here are the two pesooqim from Shemot 12:34&35, in which we read the bolded section only.

וַיִּשָּׂא הָעָם אֶת-בִּצְקוֹ, טָרֶם יֶחֱמָץ; מִשְׁאֲרֵתָם צָרֶרֶת בְּשִׁמְלֹתָם,

עַל-שִׁכְמָם

וּבְנֵי-יִשְׂרָאֵל עָשׂוּ, כְּדִבְרֵי מֹשֶׁה; וַיִּשְׂאֻהוּ, מִמִּצְרַיִם, כָּל־כֶּסֶף וְכָל־זָהָב,

וּשְׁמֹלֹת

(34) The people took their dough before it was leavened, **their kneading bowls wrapped in their cloaks upon their shoulders.** (35) **The Israelites had done Moses' bidding** and borrowed from the Egyptians objects of silver and gold, and clothing.

Something is clearly wrong, because these two verses seemingly have nothing to do with each other. By us saying “their kneading bowls wrapped in their cloaks upon their shoulders, The Israelites had done Moses' bidding”, we are confusing the punctuation of the pesooqim and reciting a statement that is unintelligible.

For years I've searched for an explanation to this dilemma without success. However, today I am thrilled to say I just discovered an answer in the writings of Hakham Yisshaq Alfiéh (Aleppo 1878 – Jerusalem 1955) in his Siah Yisshaq volume 1 (Jerusalem 1923). Hakham Yisshaq Alfiéh approaches the issue by presenting a number of questions.

- 1) Why does the Torah need to say Misharotam Seroorot... (their kneading bowls wrapped in their cloaks upon their shoulders) if it already said Vayisa Ha'am Et Bessego (the people took their dough)?
- 2) What difference does it make if they carried the kneading bowls on their shoulders, in their hands, on their donkeys, or in their vessels?
- 3) Why should it matter to us if they were wrapped or not?
- 4) Why mention wrapped in cloaks?
- 5) Why does the following pasooq say "The Children of Israel did the bidding of Moses and they borrowed..... which has no connection and it's also unclear if that has anything to do with what they borrowed?
- 6) If in fact Moses' bidding was to borrow, then shouldn't the pasooq have said: "The Children of Israel borrowed from the Egyptians; and they did as Moses said"; as is the format throughout the entire Torah, which always

mentions the action, then, that it was in accordance with the command?

7) Moreover, the Torah never says Bené Yisrael 'Asoo Kidbar Moshéh except for this one instance. The rest of the Torah says "VaYa'asoo KaAsher Sivah HaShem BeYad Moshéh" or "El Moshéh", to show the command came from the Almighty and not from Moshéh himself. This is especially troubling knowing that in Shemot 11:2, Hashem specifically told Moshéh to tell the nation to borrow from the Egyptians. So why does our verse not mention, as God commanded?

8) Lastly, if we wish to say that the bidding of Moses has to do with the dough in the previous verse, where can we find such a command from him in the text?

As I continued to read Hakham Yisshaq Alfiéh's analysis I was shocked to see that he suddenly stopped questioning the pesuqim and instead quoted just as many Halakhot from Shoolhan Arookh on Hilkhoh Pesah.

The Halakhot are as follows:

1) 459:1 = Do not knead the dough in a sunny place, and on a cloudy day you cannot knead under any cloud cover because of the sun behind the clouds. {The *Eshel Abraham*

comments that if you spread a cloth material above you, you can knead the dough}

- 2) 459:2 = The dough should not be left alone without being worked even one moment, and as long as it is being kneaded, even the entire day, it does not become hamess. If it was left without being worked for the period it takes to walk 1 mile it is then hamess.
- 3) 459:4 (*Mooram*) = One must be careful with the vessel in which the dough is kneaded; to be sure that vessel does not have any nooks or crannies.
- 4) 466:5 = Dew is like water in that it can cause a dough to become hamess. *Mooram* adds that human perspiration does not cause leavening.
- 5) 462:1 = Pure fruit juice without water does not allow the dough to turn into hamess.
- 6) 462:2 = Fruit juice with water hastens the leavening process.
- 7) 462:4 = Other beverages are considered like fruit juice.
- 8) 453:7 = When moving bags of flour from the mill, it is forbidden to place them on an animal that does not have a saddle separating the bag from the animals back. {The *Ba-*

er Heteb comments, because the flour heats up from the animal's perspiration.}

Initially I could not imagine where the Hakham was going to go with these random halakhot and why he felt it necessary to specifically mention each of them after asking so many questions about the pesooqim. Then I realized his genius. He was using them to answer the questions, by tying biblical exegesis with halakhah, minhag, and Jewish thought.

Like the laws of the Pesah sacrifice, Moshéh Rabbenoo taught Bené Yisrael all the laws of Massah and Hamess. The pasooq is written as a testimony to theses laws and the people's positive approach to fulfilling all the laws. The pasooq begins "The people took their dough before it was leavened"; meaning the dough was still kasher for baking massot. If you were to ask how did they carry their dough? Was it by donkey, or cow, or by hand, the pasooq tells you, their kneading bowls. They placed the dough in those bowls and that's how they transported it. [The RaSHBa"m explains that Misharotam are the bowls in which the dough was placed , as in Debarim 28:5, Barookh Tanakha OoMishartekha, Blessed should be your basket and your kneading bowl.]. Now you may ask, maybe these kneading bowls were not completely straight and smooth and may have had some crevices. Even if these bowls were without fault the dough was still susceptible to becoming hamess by being

exposed to the cloud that covered the nation by day, the fire that protected the nation by night, as well as the moisture from the always present dew. That being the case how could the dough still be kosher? The pasooq tells us “Seroorot BeSimlotam” “wrapped in their cloaks”. Yes, the entire dough was covered with material, on the bottom and sides to avoid the nooks and crannies of the bowl and on top to protect it from the clouds, fire, and dew that can all cause the dough to become hamess.

Wonderful, now we understand it was protected in every which way possible but there is still another problem. The people were trekking from Egypt into the desert for a distance far greater than a mile, which, according to halakhah would be a sufficient amount of time to turn the dough into hamess. Therefore the pasooq says “Al Shikhmam” “Upon their shoulders”. Why is this so important to us? Because as we know when a person walks, the entire body moves and anything carried on the shoulder moves as well. The pack of dough on the shoulder is now in constant motion and even if a person walked the entire day the dough would constantly roll around and never have a chance to rise or become hamess. This is why the pasooq found it essential to give us so many details that at first glance seemed completely unnecessary.

Looking back at the pasooq and its details and all the halakhot, why then were the bowls even necessary? They could have just wrapped the dough in material and carried it on their shoulders. The reason for that was because the dough was already kneaded with water, and if they carried them directly on their shoulders we are concerned about their perspiration. Although we know that human perspiration cannot turn it into hamess, that's only if it's by itself, but if mixed with water, the law is like fruit juice mixed with water, which hastens the leavening process, (even within a distance of less than a mile).

Finally we see that Bené Yisrael did everything to the exact letter of the law, that's the reason for the next pasooq which says "Oobné Yisrael 'Asoo Kidbar Moshéh" "The Israelites had done Moses' bidding". To tell us they followed not only *Torah Shebikhtab* (The Written Law) but *Torah SheBa'al Peh* (The Oral Law) as well, which is also called *Torat Moshéh*. We know there are laws called *Halakhah LeMoshéh MeSinai*; these are the laws of the oral Torah that Moshéh taught the nation. These laws are called Moshéh's laws even though they also came from HaShem.

This, Hakham Yisshaq Alfiéh concludes is the reason all Jews throughout the world , carry the massah on their shoulders and say MISHAROTAM SEROUROT BESIMLOTAM 'AL SHIKHMAM OUBNÉ YISRAEL 'ASOO KIDBAR MOSHEH, to proclaim that our

forefathers upheld all the laws as taught to them by Moshéh,
and we in turn will always do the same.